



WONBIN SSEM · KOREAN

1-Hour Hangul Master

Start reading Korean in under an hour

©wonbinssem

wonbinssem.com

How This Guide Works

A few notes before you start — read these once, then dive in.

Build blocks: consonant + vowel

Korean syllables start with a simple base: a **consonant** plus a **vowel**. Learn the consonants first, then plug in the vowels — that's the whole trick.

Shape clue + sound clue together

Each letter comes with a picture that matches its **shape** and a word that matches its **sound**. Use both together and the letter sticks instantly.

Read first, then check

In the practice tables, the answer sits in **light-colored text** below each block. Try to read it yourself first, then glance down to check the clue and pronunciation.

No heavy theory

Just clear shapes, simple sounds, and easy memory tricks. The goal is simple: read basic Hangul and sound out real words in under an hour.

Want the fun, guided version?

I teach all of this — and real spoken Korean — in simple, practical classes. [Book a lesson at wonbinssem.com](https://wonbinssem.com) and start speaking like a native. 👉

Start with the shape and the sound. Keep it fast and simple.



SOUND **G**



Gun

Looks like a gun. Think of the G in Gun.



SOUND **N**



Northeast

It points like northeast on a compass.



SOUND **D**



Door

It looks like a door frame.



SOUND **L**



Long line

Think of a long line. Use a light L — don't roll it like an English R.



SOUND **M**



Mail

It looks like a mail envelope.



SOUND **B**



Bucket

Think of a bucket shape.

人

SOUND S



Standing

Looks like a person standing. Start of a little family: standing, jump, child.

ㅈ

SOUND J



Jump

It's ㅅ with extra arms, like someone jumping.

ㅊ

SOUND CH



Child

Now the shape gets a top mark, like a child. Some fonts draw it a bit differently — both are correct.

ㅇ

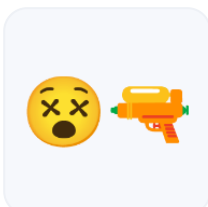
SOUND silent

Silent

Like an empty circle, a hollow ball. At the start it has no sound — just think silent.

ㅋ

SOUND K



Kill

You know ㄱ as a gun. Now it has a trigger — pull it and it can kill. (Fun: Korean texting uses ㅋㅋㅋ for laughter.)

E

SOUND T



E.T.

Looks like a capital E. Think of E.T. — the moment you see E, remember T.

π

SOUND P



Pi

It looks a little like the math symbol pi (π).

ㅎ

SOUND H



Hat

Looks like a person wearing a hat. Some fonts draw the top differently — both are correct.

Quick consonant check

Read the sound first — the clue is in light text below.

ㄱ g · Gun	ㄴ n · Northeast	ㄷ d · Door	ㄹ l · Long line	ㅁ m · Mail	ㅂ b · Bucket	ㅅ s · Standing
ㅈ j · Jump	ㅊ ch · Child	ㅇ silent · empty circle	ㅋ k · trigger → Kill	ㅌ t · E.T.	ㅍ p · Pi	ㅎ h · Hat

Basic Vowels — attach to the right

기본 모음

Basic rule: if the shape stays the same but one **extra short line** appears, just add a **Y** sound. Write the consonant first, then the vowel on its **right**.

ㅏ

SOUND ah

After

The small line comes after the long line. Think ah for After.

ㅑ

SOUND yah

Y + ah

Same shape, one extra line. Add y and get yah.

ㅓ

SOUND eo

before

Think eo from befOre. Keep it simple — just remember eo.

ㅕ

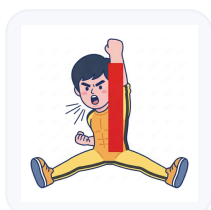
SOUND yeo

Y + eo

Same rule again. One extra line adds y, so yeo.

ㅣ

SOUND ee



ee-yah!

Think of Bruce Lee shouting “ee-yah!” with a straight arm.

Same Y-line rule. These vowels go **under** the consonant — write the consonant first, then place the vowel beneath it.



SOUND oh

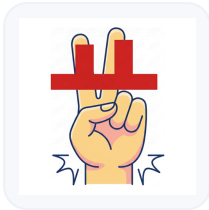


Oh... rude

Looks like a middle finger. If someone shows that, you go “oh...”.



SOUND yo



Y + oh

One extra line adds y, so yo. Imagine a rapper hand sign and say “yo!”



SOUND u



Wooo

Looks like thumbs down. Think booing “wooo.” Use a short u sound.



SOUND yu



Y + u

Add y and get yu. Or picture crying — in Korean chat, ㅠ ㅠ means tears.



SOUND eu



Eu...

Make your mouth flat like the shape and say “eu...” when something looks off. Keep it flat and short.

Basic vowel practice

Read each block, then check the clue and pronunciation below.

가 go ㄱ Gun + ㅏ After → ga	너 you (informal) ㄴ Northeast + ㅑ befOre → neo	소 cow ㅈ Standing + ㅑ oh → so
우유 milk ㅇ is silent, so only the vowels: u-yu	무 radish ㅁ Mail + ㅑ u → mu	이 this / tooth ㅇ silent + ㅣ → i

They look harder, but most are just combinations of sounds you already know. Quick shortcut: **ㅈ** and **ㅊ** sound the same for beginners, and so do **ㅊ** and **ㅊ** — no need to separate them now.

H

SOUND eh

H shape

Think of a simple “H” shape. Eh sound, as in “eh-ich.”

H

SOUND ye

Y + eh

Same rule. One extra line gives ye.

ㅈ

SOUND eh

broken H

Looks like a broken H. The sound is still eh.

ㅊ

SOUND ye

Y + broken H

Same sound family. Use ye.

Most of the rest are just two sounds pushed together. There are also three vowels that all sound like **wae** — don't worry about why.

ㅏ + ㅑ

SOUND wa

ㅏ + ㅑ

Say oh + ah quickly. It becomes wa.

ㅏ + ㅓ

SOUND wae

ㅏ + ㅓ

Say oh + eh quickly → wae. (One of three “wae” vowels.)

ㅏ

SOUND wae

just memorize

Not obvious from the shape — just memorize ㅏ = wae. (The second “wae.”)

ㅜ + ㅛ

SOUND wo

ㅜ + ㅛ

Say u + eo quickly. It becomes wo / wuh.

ㅞ

SOUND wae

ㅏ + ㅙ

Say u + eh quickly → wae. The third “wae,” often in Konglish words.

ㅟ

SOUND wi

ㅏ + ㅣ

Say u + i quickly. It becomes wi.

ㅢ

SOUND eui

ㅡ + ㅣ

Say eu + i. Keep it simple as eui.

Compound vowel mini-practice — Konglish

Read them first, then check the answer below.

밀크 셰이크

milk shake

ㅞ ≈ ㅙ sound in a Konglish word

포르쉐

Porsche

same ㅞ sound again

Double & Final Consonants

쌍자음 · 받침

Double consonants

까 · 따 · 빠 · 싸 · 짜

These are the same consonants you already know, but **stronger and tighter**. Say them with a bit more force and a sharper, slightly higher sound.

Final consonants 받침

Now a consonant appears at the **end** of the block. The key idea isn't “say the full English letter.” Stop the sound short — the mouth closes early.

- ㄱ at the end isn't a full English k. The sound stops before the burst — tiny, clipped.
- ㅂ at the end isn't a full b or p. Close the lips and stop. Very short.
- ㅅ at the end is often explained with t, but don't make a real English t — just cut it off sharply.
- ㅇ is the main exception. At the end it becomes **ng**.

Example: 안녕 — the last ㅇ makes an ng sound → annyeong.

Final consonant mini-practice

Read first, then check the sound breakdown below.

밥 rice / meal ㅂ Bucket + ㅍ After + final ㅂ → bap, last sound stops short	맛 taste ㅁ Mail + ㅌ After + final ㅌ → mat-like stop, no real t burst
국 soup ㄱ Gun + ㅊ u + final ㄱ → guk, a clipped ending	안녕 hi (informal) ㅇ silent + ㅌ + ㄴ / ㄴ + ㄷ + final ㅇ → annyeong, last ㅇ = ng

Real-Word Reading Practice
실전 읽기

Useful words for travel and everyday life. First read the Hangul, then guess the meaning, then check the pronunciation in light text.

가방 bag ga-bang	우유 milk u-yu	나라 country na-ra	버스 bus beo-seu
라떼 latte ra-tte	티 tea ti	카메라 camera ka-me-ra	지도 map ji-do
모자 hat mo-ja	바다 sea ba-da	주소 address ju-so	표 ticket pyo
문 door mun	빵 bread ppang	물 water mul	소주 soju so-ju

Try it yourself

Use the blank boxes for your own favorite travel words, menu items, or cafe orders.

Want to Master Real Korean?

The easiest, funniest, and most effective way to learn Korean

Looking for the best way to actually master Korean? You're in the right place.

I'm Wonbin Ssem :)

I customize every lesson for your goals and needs. My classes are simple, practical, and fun — and you'll learn the real Korean that people actually use.

Want to learn more? Join my class today and start speaking like a native!

- Follow me: **@wonbinssem** — Instagram / TikTok / YouTube
- Book a class: **wonbinssem.com**
- Contact: **wonbinssem@gmail.com**